

Imola inspiration: Max Verstappen (centre) with second-placed McLaren's Lando Norris (left) and third-placed Ferrari's Charles Leclerc (right). AFP

RED BULL STAYS STEADY AS CHALLENGERS EDGE CLOSER

Max Verstappen claimed his fifth win of the season at Imola after fending off a strong late challenge from Lando Norris, signalling potential **increased competition** for Red Bull.

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Max Verstappen restored normalcy at the Emilia Romagna Grand Prix with his fifth win of the season after an upset defeat at the previous round in Miami. However, for the first time this season, the reigning champion was made to work for it and had to stave off a late charge from McLaren's Lando Norris.

Earlier this year, Carlos Sainz and Ferrari gave some excitement to the season by winning the Australian GP after two years of Red Bull dominance. Granted, Verstappen retired from the race due to a technical issue, but Ferrari showed enough pace that weekend for Sainz to possibly prevail even if the Dutchman had been in the race. The three-time champion hit back strongly, producing dominant performances in Japan and China.

But in Miami, McLaren brought a range of upgrades that helped Norris take his maiden Grand Prix win and close the gap. Yes, he rode his luck with the timing of the Safety Car, but the fact that Verstappen couldn't challenge him after racing resumed showed that McLaren had made good steps.

In Imola, the Red Bull was on the backfoot from the start of the free practice session on Friday. But the reigning champion has such

a good understanding of the car that the team was able to troubleshoot itself out of a hole. Verstappen showed why he is considered the best of his generation, as he grabbed pole position by a slim margin over McLaren's Oscar Piastri.

On Sunday, Verstappen led from the front, ahead of Norris, who started second, following a three-place penalty to his teammate Piastri for impeding another car during qualifying.

As always, the Red Bull pulled away from the pursuing pack, building up a couple of seconds of lead over Norris, Leclerc, Sainz, and Piastri. At this stage, it appeared it would be another straightforward weekend for Verstappen.

However, it was not until the race's closing stages that things became interesting, as Norris slowly chipped away at Verstappen's lead, which was as high as five seconds at one point. In a matter of a few laps, Norris came within 1.5 seconds of Verstappen before running out of laps to cross the line just